

starting from 1859, to provide accommodation to European and Anglo-Indian employees. Large sprawling spaces housing quaint bungalows, neatly laid out lush lawns, and tree-lined avenues – the colonies were a reproduction of the British way of life. *The Engineers Journal* described the Cawnpore (Kanpur) railway colony in its 1858 October edition as having “good bold English architecture, something firm and solid that it does your heart good to look at.”

These spaces were a sanctum preserving racial exclusivity, an escape from the degenerating influence of the dirty, diseased tropics and those who lived in it. This policy of segregation continued even after growing Indianization forced the authorities to open up their housing policy. Indians, however, were still housed away from their European and Anglo-Indian counterparts.

A way of life

Employment in the railways also provided the Anglo-Indians with a sense of belonging. The small, tight-knit communities lived tranquil lives toeing European sensibilities, largely sequestered from Indian mores. The spatial centre of community life was the church and the Railway Institute.

Open only to Europeans and Anglo-Indians, the Railway Institute or “Inster” as the Anglo-Indians called it, were designed to be the absolute centre of social life in these isolated townships, buzzing with dances, housie nights, costume parties, or amateur theatricals. Here, one could spend evenings dancing the foxtrot, listening to a live band play, sipping chilled beer, or playing a game of whist basking in the comforts of colonial splendour. The finer among these had card rooms and billiards rooms with a table or two. Sporting facilities, such as tennis, badminton, and squash courts, and swimming pools were also made available.

The days to mark on the social calendar, however, were Christmas celebrations and New Year nights. *Burra Din* (Big Day in Hindustani) or Christmas was the event of the year, filled with traditions and a flurry of activities – children’s Christmas tree functions with teatime snacks and the arrival of Santa, the Christmas fête with a jumble sale and a raffle or two, a Christmas tableau narrating the tale of Jesus’s birth, and most importantly, a fancy dress ball preceding Christmas and the New Year’s Eve gala.